



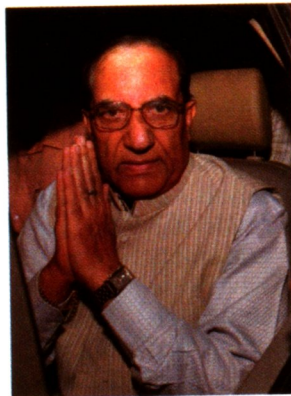
ASSEMBLY
Elections 08



Manifesto War

Shiela Dikshit now wants "special statehood" for Delhi. Ten years ago she had demanded full statehood but now she says that VIP security cannot be handled by the state and wants law and order minus this. BJP does not buy this. V.K. Malhotra plans a special package for Delhi's five lakh Sindhis, perhaps trying to please L.K. Advani. He's also promised second language status to Punjabi, but the Congress says it granted this eight years ago. *by Priya Sahgal*

MALHOTRA
(LEFT) AND
DIKSHIT



REUBEN SINGH

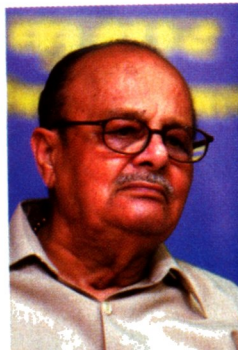


SIPRA DAS

ROYAL CHALLENGE

If looks could fetch votes, Siddhi Kumari won't have to wait till December 8 to know her fate. The 35-year-old princess of Bikaner and granddaughter of Olympian shooter, the late Karni Singh, a five-term MP from Bikaner, is among the 32 women candidates fielded by the BJP. The family has kept away from politics since 1971 when the senior Singh last won an election. Siddhi has kept herself busy looking after the family trust's museum but when Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje asked her, she quietly acquiesced—one royal doesn't say no to another. Siddhi filed her nomination in the presence of the entire clan, including grandmother Rajmata Sushila Kumari.

by Rohit Parihar



YASBANT NEGI

Killing Him Softly

Arjun Singh is stubborn. So when the party leadership discusses issues he may have strong reservations about, they talk softly. His auditory sense may have slipped, but his mind is as sharp as ever.



SAURABH SINGH

MAGIC moments

When all else fails, try some magic? Star campaigners have failed to pull in the crowds at rallies in Madhya Pradesh. So state PWD Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya roped in famed magician S. Lal to do the job. And his tricks are proving to be a hit. He waves his hand in thin air to produce a BJP flag. Or burns a piece of paper and, clenching the ashes in his fist, produces a Rs 100-note. The moral: don't sell your vote. *by Ambreesh Mishra*

33 per cent of seats is what the Congress proclaims it will give women but only 9.6% of its candidates in these polls are women.

All in the FAMILY

The family that fights together, stays together. While wheelchair-bound Ajit Jogi is trying to reclaim the chief minister's job and wife Renu is busying herself for a second term from Kota, it is son Amit who is managing the family constituencies.